

Reading

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Our Solar System: A Family of Planets

Before you read

- Look at the title. How many planets do you think are in our solar system?
- Guess: which planet do you think is the hottest?

Our solar system has one star, the Sun, and eight planets that revolve around it. The four planets closest to the Sun — Mercury, Venus, Earth and Mars — are small and rocky. The four planets farther away — Jupiter, Saturn, Uranus and Neptune — are much bigger gas giants.

Every planet orbits the Sun, but each one takes a different amount of time. Mercury orbits the Sun in just 88 days because it is close to the Sun. Neptune, the farthest planet, takes about 165 years!

Many planets also have satellites, or moons. Saturn has more than 80 moons, and its beautiful rings are made of ice and rock. Earth has only one moon, but it is very important — it affects our ocean tides.

If a planet is close to the Sun, its temperature is usually high. Venus, for example, is the hottest planet because its thick atmosphere traps heat. If a planet is far from the Sun, like Neptune, it is extremely cold.

Scientists use powerful telescopes and spacecraft to explore these planets. If we send astronauts to Mars one day, they will learn much more about the red planet and its surface.

1. What is the text mainly about?
 - a. The history of astronauts
 - b. The planets in our solar system
 - c. How to build a spacecraft
2. How many planets orbit the Sun?
 - a. Four
 - b. Eight
 - c. Eighty
3. Why does Mercury orbit the Sun so quickly?
 - a. It is very small
 - b. It is close to the Sun
 - c. It has no moons
4. Which planet is the hottest, according to the text?
 - a. Mercury
 - b. Venus
 - c. Neptune
5. Saturn has only one moon. — *True / False*

6. Why do scientists send spacecraft to explore planets?

- a. To learn more about them
- b. To live there permanently
- c. To sell rocks

After you read

- What is one fact from the text that surprised you? Write one sentence.
- Which planet would you like to explore? Why?

Earth: Our Special Planet

Before you read

- What makes Earth different from other planets? Guess two things.
- Look at the title. What do you already know about Earth's atmosphere?

Earth is the third planet from the Sun, and as far as we know, it is the only habitable planet in our solar system. But what makes Earth so special?

Earth has a thick atmosphere full of oxygen. If a planet doesn't have enough oxygen, humans and animals cannot breathe there. Earth's atmosphere also protects us from harmful rays from the Sun.

Unless a planet has liquid water, life cannot survive easily. Earth has huge oceans, rivers and lakes — about 70% of its surface is covered with water. Mars, in comparison, only has ice at its poles.

Earth's distance from the Sun is also important. It is not too close, like hot Venus, and not too far, like cold Neptune. Scientists call this the 'habitable zone'.

If astronauts explore other planets in the future, they will probably agree that Earth is still the best place for life. That's why it's so important to take care of our planet.

1. What is the main idea of the text?

- a. Earth is a boring planet
- b. Earth has special conditions that make life possible
- c. Mars is more habitable than Earth

2. What percentage of Earth's surface is covered with water?

- a. About 30%
- b. About 50%
- c. About 70%

3. What does Earth's atmosphere protect us from?

- a. Cold weather
- b. Harmful rays from the Sun
- c. Loud noises

4. What do scientists call the area where a planet's distance from the Sun is 'just right'?

- a. The rocky zone
- b. The gas zone
- c. The habitable zone

5. Mars has more water on its surface than Earth. — *True / False*

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6. How does the writer probably feel about protecting Earth?

- a. It isn't important
- b. It is very important
- c. It is impossible

After you read

- Why do you think Earth is called a 'special' planet? Write two reasons.
- Design one poster idea for your solar system project comparing Earth to another planet.